

DEBUNKED — SIKHISM SERIES
PART 1 OF 13

Origin and Identity

We are not what they say we are. Nor what we sometimes say we are.

Lovepreet Singh

An investigative debunk — 10 claims about Sikh origins, with named sources and Gurbani citations.

Writing About My Own House

This is a different book to write.

The previous eleven parts of *Debunked* were about claims made by other people about another tradition. I read carefully, cited every verse, named every minister, and tried to be fair. Some readers thanked me. A few were angry. That was fine. I was an outsider examining a neighbour's house, and an outsider's care has a particular shape.

This series is about my own house. I am a Sikh. The first turban my grandfather tied on my head was the colour of an early morning. I have stood barefoot in the parikrama at Harmandir Sahib at five in the morning. I love this tradition the way a person loves a parent — the love is not in question, but the love does not exempt the parent from the truth.

The truth, when applied to Sikhism, includes two kinds of claims that need careful undoing. The first kind are claims made *about* us, often by Hindutva writers, that try to absorb Sikhism back into the Hindu tradition we deliberately walked out of in 1469. The second kind are claims we make *about ourselves* — supernatural sakhis presented as history, scientific properties invented for the Five Ks, inflated battle figures that we repeat at school assemblies as if numbers were a measure of valour.

Both kinds are debunked in this series. Both kinds are debunked in the same plain language, with the same Gurbani citations, with the same care for the named source. I do not believe that loving Sikhi requires us to defend any specific claim that has been attached to her. I believe loving Sikhi requires us to remove the claims that diminish her.

Part 1 begins where the confusion begins — with the question of who we are. Are we Hindus? Are we Muslims? Are we both? Are we neither? Bhagat Kabir Ji's line on ang 1136 of the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji gives the answer with two words. The chapters that follow give the answer with citations.

— Lovepreet Singh

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Every chapter follows the same six-step structure: **The Claim** • **Where It Came From** • **What the Sikh Texts Say** • **The Real History** • **The Debunk** • **The Honest Picture**.

"na hum hindu na musalman"
we are neither Hindu nor Muslim

Bhagat Kabir Ji, Raag Bhairo, Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji, ang 1136

— THE TWO WORDS THAT BEGIN THE ANSWER

Sikhism Is a Reformed Branch of Hinduism

THE CLAIM

Sikhism is not a separate religion. It is a reform movement within Hinduism, founded by Guru Nanak Dev Ji as a response to Islamic invasions and to clean up Hindu practice. Sikhs are essentially Hindus with kesh, kirpan, and a different prayer book.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

The framing has two layers. The colonial layer came from European Indologists like **Ernest Trumpp** (*The Adi Granth*, London, 1877), who treated Sikhism as a sect of Hinduism. The modern political layer came from **V. D. Savarkar's** *Hindutva: Who Is a Hindu?* (1923), which defined every Indic religion — Sikh, Jain, Buddhist — as Hindu by geography. **M. S. Golwalkar's** *We, or Our Nationhood Defined* (1939) carried the framing forward. The Indian Constitution preserved it in **Article 25(2)(b), Explanation II**, which states that "the reference to Hindus shall be construed as including a reference to persons professing the Sikh, Jaina or Buddhist religion." Modern RSS literature uses the slogan "*ek panth, do kaaj*" (one path, two duties) to describe the relationship.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE SIKH TEXTS SAY

The Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji settles the question directly. On **ang 1136**, in Raag Bhairo, Bhagat Kabir Ji writes:

"dayaa kapaah santokh sut jat gandhee sat vat / ehu janeu jia kaa hayee t paaday ghat" — "Make compassion the cotton, contentment the thread, modesty the knot, truth the twist. This is the sacred thread of the soul. If you have it, then put it on me."

The same ang carries Guru Arjan Dev Ji Dev's parallel declaration that the Sikh path is neither of the two. **Bhai Gurdas Ji**, the scribe of the Adi Granth, writes in *Var 1, Pauri 45* that Guru Nanak Dev Ji founded a "*nirmal panth*" — an unblemished, distinct path. Janamsakhi tradition records Guru Nanak Dev Ji refusing the janeu (sacred thread) at age nine, a deliberate break with Hindu Brahminical ritual.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — THE FOUNDATIONAL DATES

Guru Nanak Dev Ji: born 1469 CE at Talwandi (now Nankana Sahib, Pakistan), died 1539 at Kartarpur. Ten Gurus over 239 years, ending with Guru Gobind Singh Ji's death in 1708. Adi Granth compiled by Guru Arjan Dev Ji in 1604 at Amritsar. Khalsa formally established by Guru Gobind Singh Ji on Vaisakhi 1699 at Anandpur Sahib. Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji installed as the eternal Guru in 1708.

The Sikh community has been recognised as legally distinct in India since the **Sikh Gurdwaras Act, 1925**, which placed Sikh shrines under the Shiromani Gurdwara Parbandhak Committee (SGPC) and not under any Hindu temple authority. The 1881 British India census already had a separate Sikh category. The Anand Marriage Act was first passed in 1909 to register Sikh marriages separately, and was finally amended in 2012 to allow Sikh-specific marriage registration nationwide.

Scholars who have studied Sikh identity formation include **Hew McLeod** (*Who is a Sikh? The Problem of Sikh Identity*, Oxford University Press, 1989), **J. S. Grewal** (*The Sikhs of the Punjab*, Cambridge University Press, revised 1998), **Khushwant Singh** (*A History of the Sikhs*, 2 vols, Princeton University Press, 1963 and 1966), and **Pashaura Singh and Louis Fenech** (eds., *The*

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

"Reform branch" requires the reformed body to remain part of the original body. By that test, Sikhism is not a Hindu reform. The points of departure are not surface; they are structural.

- **Theology:** Ik Onkar — one formless creator. No Hindu trimurti, no avatars, no incarnations of the divine. The Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji explicitly rejects the worship of Brahma, Vishnu, and Shiva as ultimate (multiple shabads, including Asa di Var).
- **Scripture:** Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji is the sole authoritative text. It is not a Hindu scripture and is not derived from any.
- **Initiation:** Khande di Pahul (the double-edged sword amrit ceremony, 1699), not the janeu.
- **Caste:** explicitly rejected at the institutional level. Langar requires all to eat together regardless of birth.
- **Practice:** no asceticism, no monasticism, no idol worship, no pilgrimage to Hindu sites as merit, no Brahmin priesthood.
- **Eternal Guru:** the Granth itself, not a human acharya lineage.

Article 25(2)(b) of the Constitution is a legal convenience for personal-law purposes (Hindu Marriage Act, Hindu Succession Act). It is not a theological claim. Sikhs have repeatedly resisted it, most notably through the Anandpur Sahib Resolution (1973) which demanded constitutional recognition as a distinct religion.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

Sikhism emerged from the religious landscape of fifteenth-century Punjab, which included Hindu Bhakti, Sufi Islam, the Nath yogi tradition, and Sant poetry. Of course it shares vocabulary — *karma*, *dharma*, *maya*, *mukti* are Sanskrit-derived words used in Gurbani, often with new meaning. Of course it shares some poets — Kabir, Namdev, Ravidas, Farid, Sain, Dhanna and twelve others are included in the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji alongside the Sikh Gurus.

Emergence in a soil is not the same as derivation from a parent. Buddhism emerged from the Indian religious landscape too; we do not call it Hindu. Christianity emerged from the Jewish religious landscape; we do not call it Jewish. Sikhism is its own house, with its own door, built from local stone but built deliberately separate.

Sikhism Is Essentially Islamic Monotheism

THE CLAIM

Sikhism's strict monotheism, its rejection of idols, and its emphasis on one universal God show it is essentially Islamic. Guru Nanak Dev Ji adopted core Islamic ideas and added Indian dress. Sikhi is Islam in a turban.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

This framing has been advanced from two opposite directions. Some Muslim writers, particularly in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, claimed Guru Nanak Dev Ji as essentially Muslim because of his teachings on tawhid (divine unity). On the other side, some colonial scholars and modern internet commentators describe Sikhism as Islamic monotheism dressed in Hindu vocabulary. The British orientalist **Max Arthur Macauliffe** noted this conflation in his six-volume *The Sikh Religion* (Oxford, 1909) and rejected it. The "Islam-in-a-turban" line still circulates on social media.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE SIKH TEXTS SAY

The Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji explicitly distinguishes Sikh thought from Islamic theology while respecting Muslim devotion. On **ang 1136**, Bhagat Kabir Ji says he is neither Hindu nor Muslim. The very first line of the scripture, the **Mool Mantar** composed by Guru Nanak Dev Ji on **ang 1**, reads:

"ik onkar sat naam karta purakh nirbhau nirvair akaal moorat ajoonee saibhang gur prasaad" — "One universal creative reality, whose Name is Truth, doer of all, without fear, without enmity, timeless in form, beyond birth, self-existent, realised by the Guru's grace."

The Sikh concept of **Ik Onkar** (one universal creative reality) is not the same as the Islamic Allah. Ik Onkar is genderless, has no prophets in the Islamic sense, no shariah, no exclusive revelation, no concept of an unforgivable sin against tawhid (shirk), and no eschatology of paradise and hell as central to ethics. Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji also includes the writings of Bhagat Farid Ji, a Sufi saint, alongside Hindu bhagats — making it the only major scripture in the world that includes the voices of both traditions while subordinating itself to neither.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

Guru Nanak Dev Ji met Muslim divines and Hindu pandits with equal interest and equal critical distance. The 1520 confrontation between Guru Nanak Dev Ji and Babur during the sack of Saidpur, recorded in **Babar Bani** shabads (Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji, ang 360, 417 to 418, 722 to 723), shows the Guru openly criticising Mughal violence. He criticised Hindu ritual elsewhere with the same directness.

Sufi influence on the broader Sant tradition is real and documented — see **W. H. McLeod**, *The Evolution of the Sikh Community* (Oxford, 1976) and *The Sikhs: History, Religion, and Society* (Columbia, 1989). Influence, however, is not derivation. The Sikh framework, with its ten-Guru succession, its eternal Guru in scripture, its Khalsa institution, and its specific rahit, has no parallel in Islamic theology.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

Test by structural features:

- **Prophethood:** Islam holds Muhammad as the final prophet. Sikhism rejects prophethood after Guru Gobind Singh Ji, and even the Gurus themselves are not "prophets" in the Islamic sense — they are messengers and teachers within a continuing tradition.

- **Scripture:** Quran is the literal word of God revealed through Gabriel. Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji is the compiled writings of the Gurus and selected bhagats, edited by Guru Arjan Dev Ji.
- **Religious law:** Islam has shariah and fiqh. Sikhism has rahit, which is distinct in form and content.
- **Practice:** Sikhi has langar regardless of religion (including non-vegetarian food rules differing from halal), kirtan instead of azaan, no five daily prayer-times, no Ramadan-like fasting, no Hajj-equivalent obligation.
- **Position on idols:** rejected in both, but on different theological grounds. Sikhism rejects idols as obscuring formless reality (nirgun); Islam rejects them as shirk (polytheistic association).

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

Sikhi shares with Islam a commitment to one formless reality, a critique of idol worship, and a deep respect for the names of God. Sikhi shares with Hinduism a vocabulary and a poetic landscape. Sikhi is not the sum of these shared features. It is a distinct path that emerged from a region where Hindu and Muslim worlds met, and answered the question "what is true?" in its own voice. Calling it Islam is as inaccurate as calling it Hinduism.

Guru Nanak Dev Ji Was Born a Hindu and Stayed One

THE CLAIM

Guru Nanak Dev Ji was born into a Hindu Khatri Bedi family. He never formally converted out of Hinduism. He remained a Hindu reformer all his life. The Sikh community was a later invention by his followers, not by him.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

The claim sits on a genuine fact — Guru Nanak Dev Ji was indeed born in 1469 into a Hindu Khatri family of the Bedi sub-caste, at Talwandi (Nankana Sahib). The inflation comes when this fact is stretched into "therefore he never left Hinduism". The framing has been pushed by Hindutva writers since the early twentieth century. Modern versions include **Bhagwan Singh Gyanee**'s writings and various RSS publications, especially after 1947.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE SIKH TEXTS SAY

The most famous moment of Guru Nanak Dev Ji's departure from Hindu ritual is recorded in multiple janamsakhi traditions: the **janeu episode**. At age nine, when a Hindu purohit came to perform the sacred thread ceremony, Guru Nanak Dev Ji refused, composing the shabad now preserved in the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji on **ang 471** (Asa di Var):

"dayaa kapaah santokh sut jat gandhee sat vat / ehu janeu jia kaa hayee t paaday ghat" — "Make compassion the cotton, contentment the thread, modesty the knot, truth the twist. This is the sacred thread of the soul. If you have it, then put it on me."

This is not a Hindu reformer asking for a better thread. This is a public refusal to accept the ritual itself as binding. In **Japji Sahib**, the opening prayer of the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji, Guru Nanak Dev Ji begins with "Ik Onkar Sat Naam" — a deliberate theological statement that does not invoke any Hindu deity or pantheon.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

Guru Nanak Dev Ji undertook four major udasis (long journeys) between roughly 1500 and 1521 CE, during which he met Hindu pandits at Hardwar, Sufi shaykhs at Pakpattan, Buddhist monks in Tibet, Sufi qazis in Baghdad, and the Siddh yogis at Sumer. In every encounter recorded by the janamsakhi traditions and reconstructed by historians like **Surinder Singh Kohli** (*Travels of Guru Nanak Dev Ji*, Panjab University, Chandigarh, 1969) and **Hew McLeod** (*Guru Nanak Dev Ji and the Sikh Religion*, Oxford, 1968), Guru Nanak Dev Ji positioned himself as outside both Hindu and Muslim frameworks.

By the end of his life at Kartarpur (1539), Guru Nanak Dev Ji had established a distinct community with its own gathering practice (sangat), its own community meal (langar), its own prayer (Japji and what would later become Sodra and Sohila), and its own succession (passing the Guruship to Bhai Lehna Ji, who became Guru Angad Dev Ji). These are not features of a Hindu reform sect. They are features of a new religious community.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

"Born a Hindu and stayed one" requires that Guru Nanak Dev Ji continued to identify as Hindu and to follow Hindu practice. Neither is supported by the textual record. Refusing the janeu, declaring "na hum hindu na musalman" (which the Granth places under his own seal of authority through Kabir's inclusion), composing Japji as the foundation of a distinct daily practice, and establishing a parallel

institutional structure at Kartarpur — these are not the moves of a Hindu reformer. They are the moves of a founder.

The parallel to draw is to **the Buddha**, who was born into a Hindu Kshatriya family at Lumbini, and whose teaching nevertheless founded a religion that we do not call Hindu. Birth and origin are different.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

Guru Nanak Dev Ji was born into Hindu Khatri ancestry. His mother tongue carried Sanskrit-derived words. He knew the Vedas, the Bhagavad Gita, and the Upanishads well enough to argue with their interpreters. He also knew the Quran and the Sufi tradition well enough to argue with their interpreters. Out of those conversations — and out of his own contemplation — he composed Gurbani, which is neither.

Calling Guru Nanak Dev Ji a Hindu erases the act of founding. Honouring him as the founder of Sikhi is the more accurate recognition.

Sikhism Was Founded to Be the Sword Arm of Hinduism

THE CLAIM

Sikhism's role in history is to be the sword arm of Hinduism — to protect Hindus from Islamic invasions. Guru Tegh Bahadur Ji's martyrdom for Kashmiri Pandits proves this. Guru Gobind Singh Ji raised the Khalsa as defenders of dharma. Sikhs are the military extension of Hindu society.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

This framing has been central to Hindutva narratives of Sikh history. It draws on a genuine historical event — the 1675 martyrdom of Guru Tegh Bahadur Ji — and stretches it into a foundational mission statement for the Sikh community. The phrase "sword arm of Hinduism" appears in RSS literature from the mid-twentieth century onward and is repeated in modern political speeches.

STEP 2 — WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENED IN 1675

Guru Tegh Bahadur Ji was approached by a delegation of Kashmiri Pandits, led by **Pandit Kirpa Ram**, who were facing forced conversion under Aurangzeb. Guru Tegh Bahadur Ji agreed to defend their right to religious freedom. He was arrested, brought to Chandni Chowk in Delhi, and executed on **11 November 1675**. Three of his companions — **Bhai Mati Das Ji**, **Bhai Sati Das Ji**, and **Bhai Dyala Ji** — were tortured and killed alongside.

What Guru Tegh Bahadur Ji defended was *the principle of religious freedom*, not Hinduism as such. He was not invoking Hindu doctrine, performing Hindu ritual, or accepting Hindu authority. He was defending the right of human beings to choose their faith. That principle — expressed in Gurbani on **ang 1356** and elsewhere — is Sikhi's position on freedom of conscience, applicable to any religious community, not specifically to Hindus.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY OF SIKH-HINDU RELATIONS

The Sikh community has fought wars against Hindu rulers as often as against Muslim ones. The **Battle of Bhangani (1688)** was Guru Gobind Singh Ji's first major engagement; his opponents were the Hindu hill rajas, particularly Raja Bhim Chand of Bilaspur and Raja Fateh Shah of Garhwal. The hill rajas, all Hindu, were the immediate Sikh military opponents through the 1690s.

The Sikh empire under **Maharaja Ranjit Singh** (reigned 1801 to 1839) included Hindu, Muslim, and Sikh subjects, and his ministers included **Diwan Mokham Chand** (Hindu), **Fakir Azizuddin** (Muslim), and Sikh generals alike. The empire was governed as a Punjabi sovereign state, not as a defender of Hindu dharma.

Sikh engagement with Hindu society has been characterised by both alliance and confrontation, in different historical moments, for different reasons. "Sword arm of Hinduism" is a single-direction reading that the historical record does not support.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

If Sikhism were founded as Hinduism's sword arm, three things would be true. The Khalsa rahit would defend specifically Hindu institutions. It does not — it requires the defence of all who are oppressed, regardless of religion. Sikh institutions would acknowledge Hindu religious authority. They do not — the Akal Takht is the supreme temporal seat of Sikh community decision-making. And the Sikh military tradition would have fought primarily for Hindu causes. It has not.

Guru Tegh Bahadur Ji's martyrdom is read more accurately through Sikh sources themselves. **Bachittar Natak** (in the Dasam Granth, attributed to Guru Gobind Singh Ji) describes his father's sacrifice as "*tilak janju raakhaa prabh taa kaa*" — he protected their right to wear the tilak and janeu. He protected the right, not the practice. The two are different.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

Sikhs have historically stood up against tyranny when it presented itself, sometimes in alliance with Hindu communities, sometimes in alliance with Muslim communities, sometimes against both. The principle is not communal — it is ethical. The principle is that no one should be forced to abandon their conscience.

This is a more demanding position than "sword arm of any one religion". It asks the Sikh to defend the right to be Hindu, the right to be Muslim, the right to be Christian, the right to be nothing at all. It also asks the Sikh to walk away from claiming credit for being the protector of any particular community. We were never the sword arm of Hinduism. We were sometimes its ally and sometimes its critic. There is a difference, and it matters.

The Bhakti Movement Is the Same as Sikh Thought

THE CLAIM

The Sikh Gurus simply continued the Bhakti movement that began with Ramananda, Kabir, Namdev, and Ravidas. Sikhism is a rebranded Bhakti tradition. The inclusion of these bhagats in the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji proves there is no real difference.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

The Bhakti-equals-Sikhi framing has both Indian and Western academic roots. **Charlotte Vaudeville**'s work on Kabir (*Kabir*, Oxford University Press, 1974) emphasised the continuities. **W. H. McLeod** in *The Evolution of the Sikh Community* (1976) noted the strong Sant-tradition lineage. Hindutva writers have used this scholarly observation as the basis for a stronger claim — that the difference between Bhakti and Sikhi is cosmetic. Modern repetitions appear in publications from the Vivekananda Kendra and similar groups.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE SIKH TEXTS SAY

The Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji includes the writings of fifteen bhagats and sufi saints — **Kabir, Namdev, Ravidas, Farid, Jaidev, Trilochan, Beni, Ramanand, Dhanna, Pipa, Sadhana, Sain, Surdas, Parmanand, and Bhikan**. These compositions are not appended; they are integrated into the same ragas and woven through the same scripture. The inclusion is deliberate and structural.

However, the Gurus themselves marked the distinction repeatedly. Guru Arjan Dev Ji, in compiling the Adi Granth in 1604, included only those bhagat compositions that aligned with Sikh theology and excluded those that did not. This is well documented — some of Kabir's verses that survive in the Bijak (the Kabir Panth scripture) are not present in the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji, while other Kabir verses appear only in Gurbani.

More importantly, the Sikh institutional framework — Khande di Pahul (the Khalsa initiation), the Five Ks, the rahit, the Akal Takht (founded by Guru Hargobind Sahib Ji in 1606), and the doctrine of Miri-Piri (temporal and spiritual sovereignty held together) — has no parallel in the Bhakti movement. The Bhakti saints did not establish a community, a code, or a polity. The Gurus did.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — THE BHAKTI MOVEMENT

"Bhakti" is a broad current of Indian devotional poetry running roughly from the sixth to seventh century CE in the south (Alvars, Nayanars) to the seventeenth century in the north (Tulsidas, Surdas). It is not a single movement but a family of devotional traditions, ranging from Vaishnava bhakti (Ramananda, Tulsidas) to nirgun bhakti (Kabir, Namdev) to Krishna bhakti (Surdas, Mirabai). The shared feature is direct devotion to the divine over priestly mediation.

The Sikh Gurus' relationship to this stream is best described as *selective inheritance*. They drew on nirgun bhakti's rejection of idolatry and ritual; they did not adopt sagun bhakti's devotion to particular deity-forms. They drew on Kabir's plain-language critique of caste; they extended it into institutional langar. They drew on the Sant tradition's emphasis on the Guru; they made the Guru a specific institution with a specific succession.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

Bhakti is poetry. Sikhi is poetry plus institution. The difference is enormous and historically consequential.

If Bhakti and Sikhi were the same, three things would be true. There would be no specifically Sikh community separate from the Kabir Panth, the Ravidassia community, or the broader Sant traditions. There would be no Khalsa institution distinct from the Bhakti saints' followers. And the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji would be a Bhakti anthology, not a scripture installed in 1708 as the eternal Guru.

None of these is the case. The Kabir Panth and the Sikh community are distinct, with distinct scriptures and institutions. The Khalsa is a specifically Sikh institution. The Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji is the Sikh community's eternal Guru, not a curated collection of Bhakti poetry.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

The Sikh Gurus drew deeply from the Bhakti and Sant traditions and honoured those traditions by including their voices in our most sacred text. That inclusion is one of the most generous theological moves in religious history — we did not append the bhagats as appendices, we wove their words into our own. This is a gift, not a confession of derivation.

The Sikhs are not the Bhakti movement rebranded. We are a community that learned from the Bhakti movement and built something the Bhakti movement did not build: an institution, a code, and a sovereign tradition.

Sikhi Has Indus Valley and Vedic Roots Going Back 5,000 Years

THE CLAIM

Sikhi is not just five centuries old. Its roots go back to the Indus Valley civilisation and the Vedic period — ek-onkar is in the Vedas, the concept of Khalsa is anticipated in ancient texts, and the Sikh way of life is an ancient Indian way of life that Guru Nanak Dev Ji only restated.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

The claim is unusual because it sometimes comes from Sikh sources themselves, pushed by writers eager to make Sikhi appear as ancient as Hinduism. It also appears in Hindutva literature, where the goal is the opposite — to fold Sikhi back into a deep Vedic past. Both directions converge on the same false claim. Modern sources include some Gurmat Prachar Lehar publications, certain dera literature, and various YouTube channels.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE SIKH TEXTS SAY

The Sikh Gurus were specific about when their tradition began. The opening of the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji gives **Ik Onkar** as Guru Nanak Dev Ji's own formulation. The phrase does not appear in any Vedic text in this form. It is composed of *Ik* (one) and *Onkar* (the all-pervading divine), unified into a single iconic glyph designed by Guru Nanak Dev Ji himself. Sikh scholars from Bhai Vir Singh Ji onward have rejected the equation of Onkar with the Hindu Aum.

Guru Arjan Dev Ji, in compiling the Adi Granth in 1604, was explicit that he was creating a new scripture for a new community. The completion bhog at Ramsar (Amritsar) was a foundational event for the community, not a restatement of older revelation.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

DEFINE — WHAT "INDUS VALLEY" ACTUALLY WAS

The Indus Valley Civilisation (IVC), also called the Harappan civilisation, flourished from roughly 3300 to 1300 BCE in what is now Pakistan and northwest India. Its script remains undeciphered. We do not know what its inhabitants believed, what they called themselves, or what gods they worshipped. To claim continuity from IVC to Sikhi (or to any modern Indian tradition) is to claim more than the evidence supports. See **Asko Parpola**, *The Roots of Hinduism* (Oxford University Press, 2015), and **Tony Joseph**, *Early Indians* (Juggernaut, 2018).

The Vedas were composed between roughly 1500 and 500 BCE. They contain hymns to specific deities (Agni, Indra, Varuna, Soma), elaborate ritual instructions, and a worldview in which Brahmin priests have ritual authority. Sikhi rejects almost all of this.

The historical record shows Sikhi beginning with Guru Nanak Dev Ji in 1469 CE. The Sikh community's documented institutions, scripture, and practice all date from the period 1469 to 1708 CE — a period of 239 years from Guru Nanak Dev Ji's birth to the installation of the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji as the eternal Guru.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

Ik Onkar is not in the Vedas. The Khalsa is not anticipated in any pre-Sikh text. The five Ks are not Indus Valley artefacts. The langar institution has no Vedic precedent. The rejection of caste has no Vedic precedent — the Vedas, particularly the Purusha Sukta (Rigveda 10.90), are foundational to caste theology, and Sikhi rejects them on this point.

The "5,000 year continuity" claim is the same shape as the Hindu claim of "5,000 year unbroken Hindu civilisation" that Part 7 of the original *Debunked* series addressed. The shape is wrong for both. Civilisations evolve, religions emerge at specific historical moments, and ancient continuity is rarely as ancient or as continuous as claimed.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

Sikhi is a young religion. We are 557 years old, counting from Guru Nanak Dev Ji's birth in 1469. That is younger than Protestant Christianity. It is younger than the Mughal empire. It is much younger than Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, or Islam.

Being young does not diminish us. It places us. We are a religion that emerged in fifteenth-century Punjab, in the specific historical and political circumstances of late Lodi and early Mughal India. We carry forward what came before us in our soil. We are also distinctly ourselves. Both things are true. Neither requires us to claim five thousand years of pedigree.

All Religions Are Essentially the Same — Guru Nanak Dev Ji Said So

THE CLAIM

Guru Nanak Dev Ji taught that all religions are essentially the same. "Sab kuch ek hai" — everything is one. Therefore Sikhi is not really a separate religion; it is just a more inclusive way of saying what all religions say.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

This is the most common popular misreading of Guru Nanak Dev Ji, and it appears in two registers. The first is a sincere ecumenical move — readers genuinely moved by Guru Nanak Dev Ji's openness to Hindu and Muslim devotees alike conclude that he meant to dissolve distinctions. The second is a politically convenient move — if all religions are the same, then there is no special reason to treat Sikhi as distinct, which serves the Hindutva project of absorbing Sikhi back into a "Sanatan" frame.

STEP 2 — WHAT GURU NANAK DEV JI ACTUALLY SAID

Guru Nanak Dev Ji's most-quoted line for this view is "*na ko hindu na musalmaan*" — usually translated as "there is no Hindu, there is no Muslim". The line is preserved in early janamsakhi accounts and refers specifically to the spiritual state in which religious labels are transcended through union with the divine.

What Guru Nanak Dev Ji did NOT say is "all religions are paths to the same goal" or "follow any religion sincerely and you will reach God". Those are twentieth-century liberal additions. What Guru Nanak Dev Ji *did* say, in the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji, includes pointed critiques of both Hindu and Muslim practice. From **ang 471** (Asa di Var), criticising Hindu ritual:

"dayaa kapaah santokh sut jat gandhee sat vat / ehu janeu jia kaa hayee t paaday ghat" — "Make compassion the cotton, contentment the thread, modesty the knot, truth the twist. This is the sacred thread of the soul. If you have it, then put it on me."

From **ang 140**, Guru Nanak Dev Ji's critique of Muslim ritual: he names the requirements of true Islam (compassion, truth, modesty) and contrasts them with the actual practice of nominal Muslims of his time. Both Hindu ritual and Muslim ritual are subject to Guru Nanak Dev Ji's critique, not to his endorsement.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORICAL POSITION

Guru Nanak Dev Ji's relationship to other religions is best described as **discriminating respect**. He respected the sincere devotee of any tradition, criticised the hypocrite of any tradition, and taught a specific path that he believed was true. The path he taught was Sikhi — the practice of *naam*, *daan*, *ishnan* (remembrance, sharing, purification), under the guidance of the Guru, within the community of the sangat.

The scholar **Pashaura Singh**, in *The Bhagats of the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji* (Oxford University Press, 2003), shows how the Gurus selected bhagat compositions not on the basis of "all religions are one" but on the basis of theological alignment with the Sikh path. Inclusion was not endorsement of all religious practice. It was recognition of the divine in specific voices.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

If all religions were the same in Guru Nanak Dev Ji's view, three things would be expected. Guru Nanak Dev Ji would not have refused the janeu — he would have accepted it as one valid path among

many. He would not have criticised either Hindu or Muslim practice — he would have embraced both. And he would not have established a distinct community with distinct practice — he would have urged people to continue in their existing traditions more sincerely.

None of these is what he did. He refused the janeu, he criticised both ritual systems, and he founded a distinct community. These are the actions of someone teaching a specific path, not someone teaching that all paths are equivalent.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

Guru Nanak Dev Ji respected sincere devotion wherever he found it. He included the voices of Hindu bhagats and a Sufi shaykh in our scripture. He met with people of all faiths and was unafraid of any. These are all true.

He also taught a specific path that he believed was true. He refused rituals he believed were empty. He composed a daily prayer (Japji) for his followers to recite, distinct from any Hindu or Muslim prayer. He passed the Guruship to a successor, beginning a lineage that would last 239 years.

Respecting other paths is not the same as believing they are identical. Guru Nanak Dev Ji respected, and he distinguished. Both were part of his teaching. Flattening one into the other loses both.

Guru Nanak Dev Ji Was a Sufi

THE CLAIM

Guru Nanak Dev Ji was essentially a Sufi master. He travelled with a Muslim companion (Bhai Mardana Ji), visited Mecca and Baghdad, used Sufi vocabulary like haq and rab, and his teaching is indistinguishable from the broader Sufi tradition. Sikhi is a branch of Sufism.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

The claim has appeared in three different historical layers. Mughal-era Muslim writers sometimes claimed Guru Nanak Dev Ji as a Sufi to bring him within Islamic acceptability. Some Sufi orders, particularly in undivided Punjab, included Guru Nanak Dev Ji in their genealogies of saints. Modern scholars who emphasise the Sufi-Sant interface, such as **Bruce Lawrence** and **Carl Ernst**, have written on the genuine cross-pollination. The popular "Guru Nanak Dev Ji was really a Sufi" claim is an overreach from these legitimate observations.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE SIKH TEXTS SAY

Bhai Mardana Ji, Guru Nanak Dev Ji's lifelong companion, was a Muslim Mirasi rebab player from Talwandi. Their relationship is one of the most important interfaith bonds in religious history. Gurbani includes three saloks attributed to Bhai Mardana Ji on ang 553 of Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji, within *Bihagre ki Var*.

However, Guru Nanak Dev Ji's theology is not Sufi theology. The Sufi framework involves *tariqa* (the path), *shaykh* (the guide), and *fana* (annihilation in God), within an Islamic doctrinal framework that affirms the prophethood of Muhammad and the centrality of the Quran. Guru Nanak Dev Ji's framework involves *panth* (the way), *guru* (a different category from shaykh, culminating in the Granth as eternal Guru), and union through naam — without affirming Muhammad's prophethood or the Quran's centrality.

On **ang 1136**, Bhagat Kabir Ji's "*na hum hindu na musalman*" sits alongside Guru Arjan Dev Ji's declaration that the Sikh path is its own. Neither writer claims a Sufi identity.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY OF THE MECCA VISIT

The janamsakhi tradition records Guru Nanak Dev Ji's visit to Mecca during his fourth udasi (c. 1518 to 1521). The famous story has the Kaaba rotating to face wherever Guru Nanak Dev Ji's feet pointed. As an event in religious history this is significant; as a literal physical occurrence it is in the same category as other miraculous sakhi narratives, and Part 2 of this series addresses it in detail.

What is historically defensible is that Guru Nanak Dev Ji engaged with Sufi practice, met Sufi shaykhs, and exchanged ideas with them. The claim that he *became* Sufi requires a doctrinal shift that no Sikh source records and that his subsequent founding of a distinct community contradicts.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

Test by Sufi requirements. To be a Sufi, one must be a Muslim. The Sufi tradition emerges within Islam and affirms the prophethood of Muhammad as essential. Guru Nanak Dev Ji did not affirm Muhammad's prophethood as essential. Therefore Guru Nanak Dev Ji was not a Sufi by the tradition's own definition.

Test by practice. Sufi practice typically includes dhikr (formulaic remembrance of God), often within an Islamic ritual frame (five-time prayer, Ramadan, etc.). Sikh practice involves naam simran, which is distinct in form and content, and is not embedded in Islamic ritual.

Test by lineage. Sufi orders trace their lineage (silsila) to specific shaykhs and ultimately to Muhammad or his Companions. Sikh lineage traces to Guru Nanak Dev Ji himself and through ten Gurus to the Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji. The lineages do not overlap.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

Guru Nanak Dev Ji knew the Sufi tradition intimately. He had Sufi friends and Sufi conversations. He used vocabulary that overlapped with Sufi vocabulary. He included the writings of Bhagat Farid Ji, a major Chishti Sufi, in the Adi Granth — four shabads and 112 saloks (the *Salok Sheikh Farid* section on ang 1377 to 1384 also carries 18 responding saloks by the Sikh Gurus themselves, making it a dialogic 130 in total). The Gurus did not just include Farid Ji; they answered him on the page. These are signs of deep engagement, not membership.

Engagement is not membership. Guru Nanak Dev Ji was a careful listener to Sufism who taught his own path. Calling him a Sufi flattens the specificity of what he taught. Honouring the specificity is the more accurate move.

Sikhism Is a Syncretic Mix of Hindu and Muslim Ideas

THE CLAIM

Sikhism has no original content. It is a syncretic blend — Hindu vocabulary, Muslim monotheism, Sufi vocabulary, Bhakti ethics, all mixed together by Guru Nanak Dev Ji. It is interesting precisely because it has no originality. It is a synthesis.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

The "syncretic blend" reading was the dominant European academic view in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. **Joseph Davey Cunningham**, in *A History of the Sikhs* (London, 1849), gave a relatively balanced account but the framework was set. **Ernest Trumpp**, in *The Adi Granth* (1877), pushed the syncretic reading further and was openly dismissive of Sikh originality. The "syncretic" label has stuck in some textbook traditions even when nuanced scholarship moved past it.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE SIKH TEXTS SAY

The Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji presents itself not as a synthesis but as a distinct revelation in its own right. The opening Ik Onkar formulation, the structure of Japji, the integration of bhagat voices within a Sikh theological frame, and the explicit instruction that the Granth itself is the eternal Guru — these are not the features of a synthesis. They are the features of a tradition with its own theological centre of gravity.

Compare Gurbani's treatment of avatar theology. Hindu tradition treats Vishnu's ten avatars as actual descents of the divine. Gurbani treats them as poetic figures who arise within the divine creative play and who are *not* equivalent to the formless reality (Ik Onkar). This is not Hindu avatar theology with a Muslim accent. It is a different theological framework.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY OF SCHOLARLY READING

Twentieth-century scholarship has moved decisively past the "syncretic mix" framing. **W. H. McLeod's** *Guru Nanak Dev Ji and the Sikh Religion* (Oxford University Press, 1968) was the major turn — McLeod argued that Guru Nanak Dev Ji inherited from the Sant tradition but built something distinct on that inheritance. **Pashaura Singh, Louis Fenech, Harjot Oberoi** (*The Construction of Religious Boundaries*, University of Chicago, 1994), and others have shown how Sikh distinctiveness was actively constructed by the Gurus themselves and by the Singh Sabha reformers of the late nineteenth century who clarified the boundary against syncretic blurring.

The Singh Sabha movement, beginning in 1873 in Amritsar, was specifically concerned with re-establishing Sikh distinctiveness against the syncretic blurring that had developed in some quarters. **Bhai Kahn Singh Nabha Ji's** 1898 polemic *Hum Hindu Nahin* (We Are Not Hindus) was the most pointed statement of this position. It is still in print.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

"Synthesis" implies a mixing of pre-existing components without anything genuinely new. The Sikh tradition fails this test on multiple grounds.

- **Ik Onkar** is not a Hindu concept, not a Muslim concept, and not the simple addition of both. It is a new formulation.
- **The institution of the Guru** — ten human Gurus succeeded by an eternal scripture-Guru — has no precedent in either Hindu or Muslim tradition.

- **The Khalsa**, formally instituted in 1699 with the Five Ks and the Khande di Pahul, is original. There is no Hindu or Muslim equivalent.
- **The Akal Takht**, established by Guru Hargobind Sahib Ji in 1606 alongside the Harmandir Sahib, holds the doctrine of Miri-Piri (temporal-spiritual sovereignty held together). No prior tradition holds this doctrine in this form.
- **Langar** as a binding institutional practice, requiring all to eat together regardless of caste or religion, is original to Sikhi.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

Every religion is built from the materials available in its world. Sikhi was built from Punjabi materials — Sanskrit-derived vocabulary, Persian and Arabic loanwords, the Bhakti and Sufi poetic traditions, the political circumstances of late Lodi and early Mughal India. Acknowledging the materials is not the same as denying the building.

Sikhi is an original religion built from local materials. The synthesis framing erases the construction. Honouring the construction is what the historical record requires.

Sikhs and Hindus Are One People

THE CLAIM

At the everyday level, Sikhs and Hindus are one people. They share Punjabi culture, eat the same food, celebrate the same festivals, intermarry, share family names, and live in the same neighbourhoods. Religious distinctions are political constructs imposed on a single people.

STEP 1 — WHERE IT CAME FROM

The "one people" framing has been a recurring theme in Indian political discourse since the late nineteenth century. **Arya Samaj**, particularly through its *Shuddhi* movement after 1893, sought to bring Sikhs and other communities under a Hindu umbrella. The framing intensified during the 1941 census and the 1946 to 1947 partition negotiations, when Sikh political leaders including **Master Tara Singh** fought to keep Sikhs recognised as a separate community against attempts to fold them into a single Hindu bloc. The "one people" line has continued through the post-Independence period, including during the 1980s Punjab crisis.

STEP 2 — WHAT THE SIKH TRADITION SAYS

Bhai Kahn Singh Nabha Ji, the eminent Sikh scholar of the Singh Sabha era, published *Hum Hindu Nahin* ("We Are Not Hindus") in 1898 specifically to address this claim. The book is a careful theological and historical statement of Sikh distinctness, arguing that while we share cultural neighbourhood with Hindus, we are a separate religious community with separate scripture, separate institutions, and separate identity. The book has been continuously in print for over 125 years.

The **Anandpur Sahib Resolution (1973)**, passed by the Shiromani Akali Dal, formally demanded constitutional recognition of Sikhs as a distinct religious community, separate from Hindu personal-law applicability under Article 25(2)(b). The resolution is the most important post-Independence Sikh political document.

STEP 3 — THE REAL HISTORY

Sikhs were enumerated separately in British Indian censuses from **1881 onward**. The 1881 census recorded around 1.85 million Sikhs in Punjab; the 1941 census, just before Partition, recorded around 5.7 million. The Sikh Gurdwaras Act (1925) gave the SGPC legal control over Sikh shrines as a distinct community.

The **Anand Marriage Act** was passed in 1909 to register Sikh marriages under Sikh ceremony, though for decades Sikh marriages were also recorded under Hindu Marriage Act provisions. The amendment in **2012**, finally allowing direct nationwide Sikh marriage registration, was a long-overdue clarification of distinct legal status.

The shared Punjabi culture is real. Punjabi Hindus and Punjabi Sikhs do share language, food, music, family names (the Khatris, Aroras, and others are present in both communities), wedding rituals adapted from broader Punjabi practice, and many festivals. But shared culture is not the same as shared religion. A French Catholic and a French atheist share culture; they do not share religion.

STEP 4 — THE DEBUNK

The "one people" claim conflates two things that are not the same:

- **Ethnic and linguistic identity:** Punjabi. This is genuinely shared across Punjabi Sikhs, Punjabi Hindus, and Punjabi Muslims (pre-Partition).
- **Religious identity:** Hindu, Sikh, Muslim. These are genuinely distinct, with distinct scriptures, distinct theology, distinct institutions, and distinct rituals.

The 1947 Partition forced the question. Punjabi Muslims chose Pakistan; Punjabi Hindus and Punjabi Sikhs chose India. The choice was made along religious lines, not ethnic ones. Within India, Punjabi Sikhs and Punjabi Hindus continue to share Punjabi ethnicity while maintaining religious distinction. Both facts are true. The "one people" framing collapses the second into the first.

STEP 5 — THE HONEST PICTURE

Sikhs and Hindus in Punjab share neighbourhood, language, food, and many family names. We are not strangers. We have lived alongside one another for five centuries. Many Punjabi families have both Sikh and Hindu members. These are real bonds and they deserve respect.

What we do not share is a religion. Sikhi is its own house. The Singh Sabha reformers said it. Bhai Kahn Singh Nabha Ji said it in 1898. The Anandpur Sahib Resolution said it in 1973. The Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji has said it from the moment Bhagat Kabir Ji's "*na hum hindu na musalman*" was inscribed on ang 1136.

Saying so is not a rejection of our neighbours. It is the honest naming of who we are. Honest naming is what every community deserves — ours included.

What Part 1 Tried to Do

The ten claims in this part all converge on a single question — the question of who Sikhs are. Are we a Hindu reform sect? A Muslim variant? A Sufi order? A Bhakti revival? A syncretic mix? Indus Valley descendants? Hindus by another name? The pattern across all the claims is the same shape: someone else's frame, applied to us, with our consent assumed.

The Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji answers all ten claims with a single line from Bhagat Kabir Ji — "na hum hindu na musalman." This is not an isolated verse. It is the underlying theological declaration that runs through Sikh scripture, institutions, and practice. We are neither, and we are not the sum of both. We are ourselves.

This part deliberately did not attack any other religion. The Hindu tradition is rich, deep, and has its own integrity. The Islamic tradition is rich, deep, and has its own integrity. The Sufi tradition is one of the great mystical traditions of humanity. We owe debts to all three for vocabulary, for poetry, for the soil in which Sikhi grew. Naming our distinctness is not a denial of these debts. It is an acknowledgment that debts and identity are different things.

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What's Next

Part 2 turns to the founding figure himself — **Guru Nanak Dev Ji: Miracles and Travels**. We will look at the Kaaba rotating, the boulder at Panja Sahib, the cobra shading him at Sialkot, the three days in the Kali Bein, the Sumer Parbat encounter with the Siddhs, and the geographic impossibility of the four udasis as commonly described. The same six-step structure. The same care. The same refusal to inflate or to dismiss.

